30,000 cavalry, and 9,000 elephants: whence may be formed some conjecture as to the vastness of his resources'.

Strabo's paraphrasing of Megasthenes suggests that the kingdom has 'an aristocratical form of government consisting of five thousand councillors, each of whom furnishes the state with an elephant'. Megasthenes, via Diodorus, suggests that in earlier times, cities had 'the democratic form of government', but in his own time, administration was centralized. It seems to have some features of the idealized bureaucracy advocated by the *Arthashastra* of Kautilya, who may have been Chandragupta's chief minister (at best, only parts of the surviving *Arthashastra* date from his time; much of the text was created by later authors as late as third century CE[20]). Megasthenes lists a range of officials that run the bureaucracy of the state—overseers of markets, trade, the city, harbours, soldiers, water sluices, roads, births and deaths, land use, taxation, weights and measures, foreigners, etc.—though it's unclear how far out of Pataliputra their reach extended.

Theft is very rare and people leave their homes and property unguarded. As for punishment, Megasthenes writes, 'A person convicted of bearing false witness suffers mutilation of his extremities. He who maims any one not only suffers in return the loss of the same limb, but his hand also is cut off. If he causes an artisan to lose his hand or his eye, he is put to death.' A sales tax of 10 per cent is levied and any 'fraud in the payment of this tax is punished with death'. It's not clear how often this happened (it's common across ages to have poorly enforced criminal laws on the books).

'They never drink wine except at sacrifices. Their beverage is a liquor composed from rice instead of barley, and their food is principally a rice pottage.' Apparently, they always eat alone and 'have no fixed hours when meals are to be taken by all in common, but each one eats when he feels inclined'. Three centuries later, Strabo wagged a finger at this tidbit, adding, 'The contrary custom would be better for the ends of social and civil life' (as was common with the Greeks). Megasthenes's observation is puzzling; perhaps Strabo erred in paraphrasing it. Megasthenes likely meant that each family ate alone, not communally. Or perhaps he may have seen that in upper-class families, the head of the household ate first and was served apart from the family, a custom common until recent times.[21]